

Psalm 73, You Cannot Aim by Willpower

Roughly 1,300 words. Scripture NIV. The reading plan behind this has five stages and thirteen Pauline cross-references. None of that is in the episode. It is the mine, not the video.

1. The address

There is a person you want something from that they cannot give you.

Not a favour. Something underneath that. You want them to look at you and settle the question of whether you are real. And you have probably noticed that when they do give you attention it does not settle anything, it lasts about four days, and then you need it again.

That appetite is not a defect. It is standard equipment, and it is enormous, and it was built for something that does not need you and is not lacking. What it does not have is an off switch. If the thing it was made for is unavailable or unrecognised, it does not shut down and wait politely. It goes sideways and installs the nearest available human in the slot.

That is the condition this psalm is about, and the man who wrote it names it in the second line.

One thing to hold as we read. He is not watching a person. He is watching a class, the wicked, plural, all the way through. If yours is one specific human being, that changes nothing about the mechanism. It only makes it harder to see, because a class is obviously an abstraction and a face is not.

2. The text

Read Psalm 73 whole. All of it, no commentary, no annotation while reading.

Let it sit.

3. The difficulty

Here is the problem with everything I just said, and it is a serious one.

The standard advice at this point is: desire God more. Want him instead. Redirect your heart.

That is not actionable. It is not even coherent. You cannot want something by deciding to want it. Try it right now with anything, a food you dislike, a person you are not drawn to. Nothing happens. Wanting is not under the control of the will, which is exactly why it runs your life instead of the other way round.

So when someone hands you Psalm 42, as the deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, my God, and you feel nothing remotely like panting, the psalm does not read as help. It reads as an accusation. Or worse, you say it anyway and you know while you are saying it that you do not mean it, and now you have added dishonesty to the pile.

If the psalms are a device for producing the correct feeling, they fail for the people who need them most, and they turn everyone else into a liar.

4. The turn

The way out is a fact about desire that the psalter seems to have known three thousand years before anyone wrote it down properly.

Desire is never direct.

You have never once wanted anything by yourself. It always comes through someone. You wanted the job because of the man who had it, the life because of the people living it, the person because of who else wanted them. Girard calls the sideways version of this deviated transcendence, a vertical appetite aimed horizontally, and the reason he matters here is not the vocabulary. It is the consequence.

If desire is always copied, then "want less" is not on the menu and neither is "redirect by force." There has only ever been one lever, and it is not the wanting. It is the model. Who you are looking at.

And the psalter states this as a law. Psalm 115 is talking about idols, the ones with mouths that cannot speak and eyes that cannot see, and then:

115:8. "Those who make them will be like them, and so will all who trust in them."

That is not a warning about statues. It is a physics of the person. You become what you look at. Whatever you have installed in the slot is forming you into its own shape right now, whether it is a god, a career, or a specific person who does not know they are carrying this.

Which tells you what a psalm actually is. Not a feeling to be generated. An address to be said. It aims you by putting a direction in your mouth on the days you cannot produce one, and the aiming happens whether or not the feeling has arrived yet.

5. The pressure

Test one. Does the psalm actually work that way?

Watch the mechanism in the text.

73:2-3. "But as for me, my feet had almost slipped; I had nearly lost my foothold. For I envied the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked."

He is not describing doubt about doctrine. He is describing envy, which is the one appetite that cannot exist without a model. Rage at injustice does not need anybody to copy. Envy is nothing but copying. And he spends sixteen verses watching them, cataloguing their bodies and their ease and their mouths.

Notice also what he envies. Where our translation has prosperity, the Greek psalter has peace. He is not envying their possessions. He is envying their untroubledness, the fact that nothing inside them is asking a question.

Then two verses that decide whether this is really about wanting, or about justice.

73:13. "Surely in vain I have kept my heart pure and have washed my hands in innocence."

Hear what the complaint actually is. Not that the wicked are hurting anyone. That his own purity bought him nothing. That is not moral outrage, it is a wage dispute. And the Greek is blunter than the English. Mataiōs edikaiōsa tēn kardian mou. In vain I justified my heart. He had been running his own righteousness as a payment scheme, and he was watching other men get paid without paying.

73:22. "I was senseless and ignorant; I was a brute beast before you."

That is his own verdict, delivered after the sanctuary, on the state he was just in. If the problem had been righteous anger at injustice, the sanctuary would have confirmed it and told him to be patient. It does not. It tells him he was ktēnōdēs, cattle. And an animal is precisely the thing that wants without knowing why it wants.

Then:

73:16-17. "When I tried to understand all this, it troubled me deeply till I entered the sanctuary of God; then I understood their final destiny."

Read what breaks it. He tried to understand and it troubled him deeply, which is the honest report of a man who reasoned at the problem and got nowhere. The thing that turns it is not an argument. It is a location. He went somewhere. And the seeing changed after the going, not before.

That is the whole method in one verse. He did not think his way out of envy. He changed what was in front of his eyes, and the desire followed the eyes.

Test two. Then is this just a mood technology?

If the psalms were a device for feeling better, Psalm 88 should not exist.

Read how it ends. Darkness is my closest friend. That is the last line. There is no turn, no resolution, no lifting at the end, and the collection kept it anyway and put it in the book people pray from.

Which tells you the tool is not a mood improver, because a mood improver with a failure case that stark would have been edited. It survived because it is an address. Psalm 88 is a man speaking to God with nothing good to report and no improvement to show, and it is still aimed. The direction is intact even when everything else is gone.

That is the strongest evidence that these things are not about generating a state.

Test three. What do you bring on a day you have nothing?

This is the one that would break it, because a technology that requires you to arrive in a certain condition is useless exactly when you need it.

51:17. "My sacrifice, O God, is a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart you, God, will not despise."

Notice what is being offered. Not repentance completed, not sorrow of the right quality, not a resolution to do better. A broken thing. The entry requirement is that you have nothing, and the verse exists to tell you that nothing is accepted material.

So the tool has no inventory requirement. There is no state you have to reach before you are allowed to use it.

6. The landing

The psalm does not end where you expect.

73:25-26. "Whom have I in heaven but you? And earth has nothing I desire besides you. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

He does not say the wicked turned out to be miserable. He does not say he stopped wanting. He says his flesh and his heart may fail, which is a man admitting the appetite is still there and still capable of taking him down, and then he names what it is for.

And the Greek is harder than "may fail." The verb is past. Exelipen. My heart and my flesh failed, which is how the Orthodox psalter carries it. Not a risk he is warning you about. A collapse he has already been

through. He is telling you this from the far side of it.

And here is what this leaves on you.

You are being formed into the shape of something right now. Not eventually, not if you get careless. Now, by whatever is in the slot, according to a law you did not consent to and cannot switch off. The question is never whether you are copying. It is only what.

Which means the thing you have been treating as optional, the saying of words you do not feel on days you have nothing, is not a devotional extra for people who are already doing well.

It is the only lever you have.

Open loop, one sentence: if you become what you look at, the next question is what happens to a man who looks at someone who does not grasp, and that is Philippians 2.

Apparatus. Not spoken.

Reference only, for the board and for questions afterwards. None of this goes to camera except the three transliterated words already in the body.

Numbering. This is Psalm 73 in the Hebrew and in the NIV. It is **Psalm 72** in the Septuagint and in the Orthodox psalters. Verse numbers below are the Hebrew ones.

Sources. NIV. Greek from Swete and Rahlfs, cross-checked. English of the Greek from the Staats LXX psalter ([~/Downloads/OrthodoxPsalter2.pdf](#)); the Seraphim psalter ([~/Downloads/psalter-3rd-ed-15july2013.pdf](#)) agrees at every point below.

v.	NIV	LXX in English	Greek	What the Greek adds
3	"I envied the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked"	"I was envious of the wicked, seeing the peace of sinners"	ὅτι ἐζήλωσα ἐπὶ τοῖς ἀνόμοις, εἰρήνην ἀμαρτωλῶν θεωρῶν	The object of envy is not goods but untroubledness. ἐζήλωσα is ζήλος, the same root Paul puts in the vice lists and James puts at 3:14-16
13	"in vain I have kept my heart pure "	"I have kept righteousness in my heart to no avail"	ἄρα ματαίως ἐδικαίωσα τὴν καρδίαν μου	ἐδικαίωσα is <i>justified</i> , the Pauline verb. Makes the wage-complaint explicit, purity run as a payment scheme
16	"it troubled me deeply "	"it was too toilsome for me"	τοῦτο κόπος ἐστὶν ἐναντίον μου	κόπος is labour, not distress. He worked at it and the work failed. Strengthens "not an argument, a location"
17	"then I understood their final destiny "	"then understood I their end "	καὶ συνῶ εἰς τὰ ἔσχατα αὐτῶν	τὰ ἔσχατα, the eschata. The sanctuary gives him the end of the story, not a better argument

v.	NIV	LXX in English	Greek	What the Greek adds
22	"I was a brute beast before you"	"I became like a beast before thee"	κτηνώδης ἐγενόμην παρά σοί	κτηῖνος is livestock. Not a wild beast raging, a domestic animal wanting. Hebrew has תולדות, behemoth
25	"earth has nothing I desire besides you"	"what on the earth did I desire but thee"	παρά σοῦ τί ἠθέλησα ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς	The landing is in the vocabulary of wanting, not of justice
26	"my flesh and my heart may fail "	"my heart and my flesh failed "	ἐξέλειπεν ἡ καρδία μου καὶ ἡ σὰρξ μου	Aorist. The collapse already happened. He speaks from after it, not before it

Hebrew at v.3. יתנני, *qinne'ti*, from נתן. Envy and jealousy are one word-field in both languages, which is why the psalm can be read as rage. The tell that it is envy and not rage is v.13, where the grievance turns out to be his own unpaid wages.

The objection this answers. Someone will say the psalm is about theodicy and the prosperity of the wicked, not about desire. Two replies. First, proportion. v.17 settles the justice question in half a verse and the remaining eleven verses are about what he now wants. Second, v.22. The psalmist's own post-sanctuary verdict on his earlier state is not "I was right but impatient." It is "I was a beast." The psalm names its own disease and the name is not rage.

Deliberately left out. vv.18-20, the judgment language, slippery ground and swept away and despised as fantasies. It is the strongest textual support for the rage reading and there is no room for it. If a comment raises it, the answer is that v.20 makes the wicked *a dream when one awakes*, which is an unreality verdict, not a punishment verdict, and unreality is exactly the complaint the model was supposed to solve.